

Google announced the Open Automotive Alliance (OAA) – yet another consortium that would indicate the nature of collaborative alliances that have now become common in the automobile space.

The OAA is a group of companies that aim to use Android as the platform of operation within cars, not just for infotainment. This alliance suggests the use of Android OS as the core platform on which car systems can be built, and have their own suite of connectivity options and apps. This, in turn, will facilitate phone-free usage of car systems, which till now have been heavily reliant on phones. The OAA has NVIDIA as the prime chip provider, and Google as the software maker, with a wide range of notable car makers and in-car system manufacturers listed as partners.

Nevertheless, the first leg of the OAA's mission has been to establish Android Auto as a de facto infotainment standard in cars, and to an extent, it has managed to strike a balance between form and functionality, although not without compromises. First introduced with Android Lollipop (v5.0), Android Auto presents a familiar Android interface with floating cards that provide information, and can be operated via touch, physical control buttons on the car's dash, or voice. It also integrates the Google Assistant voice assistant that allows users to feed navigational information, make calls, change songs and more. Application support has been Android Auto's greatest strength, and along with Google Maps, Play Music, Android Auto supports a host of third party applications like WhatsApp, Spotify and more.

For a more detailed analysis of Android Auto, and how it fares against Apple CarPlay, visit here: <http://dgit.in/andavcp>

Looking Forward: Android in Cars

The next step, seeing that Android Auto is almost nearing maturity, is to present systems that run directly on Android OS. These systems will benefit from the rising connected car telematics, wherein the car itself integrates data connectivity into its system, and the system functions pretty much like an independent smartphone.

As a result, a user can leave their phone behind, and still get all call and message prompts on his car system, as long as the accounts are synced. Alongside, the system will integrate all car dynamics, mechanical data, sub-systems (air conditioning, seat adjustments, etc.) along with an app store, and live GPS data, to aid cross-car connectivity.

In functionality, Android in cars is similar to the likes of Automotive Grade Linux, which also aims to provide an open source platform for